

Arlington, Washington City P.O.
20 April 1861

Hon^{ble} Simon Cameron
Sec^y of War

Sir

I have the honour to tender
the resignation of my Commission as Colonel
of the 1st Reg^t of Cavalry

Very res^t your obtst

R. E. Lee
Col 1st Cav

Letter of resignation

On April 20, 1861, Lee resigned from the U.S. Army in order to take up arms against the United States in a rebellion begun by wealthy slaveholders.

Early military career

After studying at West Point Military Academy, Lee spent his pre-Civil War career in the engineers and then the cavalry. He served as a staff officer during the War with Mexico in 1847–48, when his talent for imaginative flanking movements around prepared defenses and coolness under pressure earned the admiration of his commander, General Winfield Scott. Yet, by the time Lee entered his fifties, his military career had stalled; his overriding concerns were his wife's health and the Arlington estate.

Lee was on extended leave because of these issues when called to suppress the revolt of the abolitionist John Brown at Harpers Ferry in 1859. The approach of Civil War in 1861 made Lee—still a